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Title:

Beauty and the Beast: Human Resources

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BEAUTY AND THE BEAST: HUMAN RESOURCES

(*AUTHOR'S NOTE: Knowledge of the movie or fairy tale should not be necessary for the audience or performer. However, the piece was written in an open way that a performer or performers who wish to bring characters from the movie to life can do so.*)

Written to be performed as a DUO, although an ambitious performer could probably do it as an HI. Specific gender should not be necessary for most characters. Depending on competition rules for changing a piece, the "Prince" nomenclature could be changed to "Princess" to make it a true Female / Female DUO.

Characters (With a suggested split between the two performers):

Witch - Performer 1
Narrator - Performer 1
Prince / Beast - Performer 2
Plate - Performer 2
Broom - Performer 1
Servant 1 / Coat Rack - Performer 1
Cup - Performer 1
Bucket - Performer 2
Footstool - Performer 2
Knife - Performer 1
Pan - Performer 1
Girl - Performer 1

(*If performing as a DUO, Performer 2 starts center facing judge. Performer 1 starts back to Performer 2, facing upstate [back wall]*).

NARRATOR: There lived a prince.

PRINCE: Hi there!

NARRATOR: The prince was a very selfish and terrible and abusive and vile prince.

PRINCE: Whoah.

NARRATOR: Who cheated through not only high school, but middle school, and even elementary school.

PRINCE: 11 and 12 should be oneteen and twoteen.

NARRATOR: The prince lived in a castle with many servants high above the town. And never went into town, probably because no one likes the prince.

PRINCE: People like me.I was elected to the secret homecoming court.

NARRATOR: What?

PRINCE: All four years of high school, I was elected to the special homecoming court. No one else ever was. It was a special honor, reserved only for the most important and special people in the whole school. I won it. Four years running.

NARRATOR: (Turns a bit to face the audience.) Are you serious right now?

PRINCE: I had my own VIP dance, very special. I had my own room, all to myself. No one else was allowed in.

NARRATOR: (Stares at audience for a beat.) I have to ask, sorry. Where was this room?

PRINCE: Basement, past the custodians closet. The theme was “Storage Closet”.

NARRATOR: Um…

PRINCE: (Cuts off.) Same theme all four years. Can you believe it? Even reused the decorations. My classmates had no creativity at all. But as my parents said, I must spend time amongst the vile, unwashed, terrible hoi polloi to …..

NARRATOR: (Cuts off) …become a great prince?

PRINCE: (Continues) … to realize how lucky I am and to realize their inferiority so I never ever ever help them or care about them.

NARRATOR: Right. And there we go. Cue witch.

PRINCE: Witch? Pff. So long as it isn't a clown. Am I right?

NARRATOR: It was a dark and stormy night, the wind howled, the trees shook, and there was a knock at the castle door…..(Makes knocking sound.)

PRINCE: Servant! Get the door! It might be my pizza!

SERVANT 1: On it!

PRINCE: Don't you dare tip!

SERVANT 1: Um, it's for you!

PRINCE: No one comes to visit me. (Walks over to door.)

WITCH: Please, dear prince, I am but a poor woman caught in this storm. Could I please rest inside your giant castle until it passes? Perhaps use the bathroom. Perhaps get a cup of warm soup? Chicken Tortilla if you have it.

PRINCE: Vile woman. You disgrace my very opening. And then to have the gall to ask for soup?

WITCH: Do not turn me away, to do so would be to invite my wrath.

PRINCE: The wrath of an old, shriveled woman who likes soup? Pff. I care not. (Door Slams).

WITCH: (knocking)

PRINCE: Pizza! (Opens door.) You?!

WITCH: It is indeed I. But I am not a old, shriveled woman who likes soup. I am a (TRANSFORMATION)...

PRINCE: GASP! And other exclamations of amazement because of the lack of special effects to connote stunning transformation!

WITCH: …. A stunningly beautiful age-appropriate witch with perfect posture. (Pause) I do still like soup.

PRINCE: Ghastly!

WITCH: You have failed the test.

PRINCE: Test? But I didn't have anyone to cheat off of!

WITCH: For your lack of kindness, I will put a curse on you and all who live in your castle.

PRINCE: It's literally just me.

WITCH: No, it extends to all of your servants.

PRINCE: I don't count them.

WITCH: This night you will transform into a vile beast, so that you are as ugly in your outward appearance as the hollows of your soul.

PRINCE: No! I am butt ugly in the hollows of my soul!

WITCH: The curse will only be broken when you get an intelligent, independent woman to fall in love with you.

PRINCE: Those are odd qualifiers. That usually isn't my type…. So, what are the rules to this curse?

WITCH: There are literally hundreds. Which is why you need to get your rest. I will be back in the morning, 9 am sharp. Make sure everyone is here in the morning. I have a 6 hour presentation about the curse. Boilerplate human resources stuff. I have other people to curse, so I want to make good use of our time. Until the morn! (POOF disappear.)

PRINCE: She has disappeared in a cloud of smoke, and a crackle of electricity, leaving a faintly sulfurous smell in the air.

SERVANT 1: That was intense.

PRINCE: WHAT? You heard the whole thing?

SERVANT 1: We are cursed.

PRINCE: Have no fear. It was but an idle threat. You will see, come morning, that we have nothing to fear.

(PRINCE turns upstage, NARRATOR now faces the audience).

NARRATOR: And thus began the curse of the prince and castle. For in the morning is the human resources meeting. As for the Prince, well, the prince found a mirror.

PRINCE: (from upstate) NOOOOO, I AM AS BUTT UGLY AS THE HOLLOWS OF MY SOUL!

SUGGESTED INTRODUCTION BREAK - But you cut this as you see fit.

NARRATOR: Morning comes. 9:01 am.

WITCH: Settle down, settle down. Where's the prince?

PLATE: Still sleeping, but can we address why I am now a plate?

BROOM: Why am I a broom? I was a cook. And now I'm a broom.

PLATE: So many questions.

CUP: If someone pours scalding hot coffee into me, does that hurt now?

BUCKET: Please tell me I am not a bucket to be used for what I think I am a bucket for?

WITCH: I would actually go sit by the prince's bed, you can get caught up later.

BUCKET: That's what I thought. Sh…

WITCH: (Cuts off). Okay then. Welcome all to the human resources presentation, "So You Woke Up Cursed, What Now?" I'm your host, the witch.

BUCKET: …it better be a good presentation. Someone take notes!

WITCH: Tough morning already, huh?

PLATE: So, let me get this straight…(Is interrupted)

WITCH: (Interrupts) Or, let me get this plate, am I right?

FOOTSTOOL: Wordplay! (Laughs)

BROOM: This is no laughing matter.

FOOTSTOOL: Gotta find the bright side of things.

WITCH: Love the attitude there. So, today, I am going to explain the rules of the curse, go over any questions, and then hopefully get you started on breaking the curse.

PLATE: Ok, so…(is interrupted)

WITCH: (Interrupting) Just, real quick. There will be a break for lunch. It is on your own. Nothing will be provided. I ask that you not go into town, just in case you don't make it back for the afternoon portion. Also, you know we want to avoid mass panic.

FOOTSTOOL: Makes total sense. I like clear communication. Appreciate you.

WITCH: Appreciate you.

PLATE: WHY AM I A PLATE?

WITCH: Oh, that's quite simple. You are a plate because your prince didn't offer me safe haven from the storm. Or soup.

PLATE: And so why am I cursed for that? For something the prince did?

WITCH: Because you work for the prince.

PLATE: I had to work for the prince, do you realize what inflation is? My rent skyrocketed. And the inn in town was cutting back on jobs.

BROOM: I had to close my bookstore, I only had one customer, and since she was attractive I always gave her a discount.

FOOTSTOOL: Foreshadowing!

CUP: I'm just here because it was take your kid to work day yesterday! I don't even work here!

FOOTSTOOL: Right, I was wondering who you were. I thought you were KNIFE for a moment.

KNIFE: I'm back here!

FOOTSTOOL: Hi Anita! I can't see you!

KNIFE: I'm a knife!

FOOTSTOOL: Butter?

KNIFE: Butcher's!

FOOTSTOOL: Nice!

WITCH: Okay then. Cup, I'm sure it will be a good learning experience for you.

CUP: I'm a cup!

WITCH: Now you will see the world through a different perspective.

PLATE: Listen, witch, I understand you are a witch. And so are evil.

WITCH: Whoah, that's a pretty big stereotype.

PLATE: You turned good, kind, decent people into kitchenware and common household items.

WITCH: Right, I cursed you.

PLATE: Why not animals? Or beasts? Like the prince?

WITCH: Oh, that's easy, it's the prince's curse. The prince's soul. Or hollows of the soul, more accurately.

PLATE: But that doesn't explain why kitchenware and common household items. I saw a dressing cabinet back there.

WITCH: Well, what if you have a guest and want to make a big song and dance about making dinner? And then the guest has to get dressed for dinner. You know?

FOOTSTOOL: Ohhh, it all makes sense now.

CUP: Will the guest break the curse?

PLATE: This seems like we are here solely for the prince and we are not really in control of anything.

WITCH: You get it.

PLATE: We did nothing wrong except, maybe, just maybe, work for somebody who was not a good person.

WITCH: A very vile person.

PLATE: That isn't us.

WITCH: But you supported it.

PLATE: We had no other option. There is an economic reality. We have to work. And get paid.

WITCH: And he probably paid you next to nothing.

FOOTSTOOL: Actually, he was rather competitive.

COAT RACK: He wasn't very good with money.

PLATE: I will concede he didn't think he was paying us much, but he was comparing our wages to what his allowance was when a child so, he was …accidentally generous.

KNIFE: He once gave me a raise every week for a month!

FOOTSTOOL: Taylor ruined that one, told the prince every 6 months was typical.

PAN: Sorry! I thought that was common knowledge!

PLATE: So, why should we suffer?

WITCH: That's the way of the system, my dear. The way things are.

PLATE: So, how do we break the curse? Let's just break it and get back to normal.

WITCH: Great question. The prince, now a beast, a ghastly beast, and sort of smelly, must get an intelligent, independent woman to fall in love with him.

FOOTSTOOL: How do we know if she's intelligent and independent?

WITCH: Just make sure she likes books.

PLATE: Right, that's how he breaks his curse. How do I break my curse? Because I have a loving spouse at home in town, already loves me. So?

WITCH: I'm not finished. The prince has until this rose (shows rose) loses its last petal. After that, the curse is permanent.

BUCKET: Sorry to interrupt, Bucket here, the prince is still sleeping. Quick question though, this is a little awkward, when I have to go to the bathroom, do I use….(pause as trails off, half points to self)

WITCH: Well, you are (pause) what you are.

BUCKET: Right. So….(trails off awkwardly, points back at self)

WITCH: (A little uncomfortable) Yeah. There's always one. If it makes you feel any better, it's usually the nicest, most kind, open, loving, trusting person who gets your transformation.

BUCKET: Yup. That tracks. Okay then. Okay then. (Deep breath). I'll go be me, then. I guess.

COAT RACK: Super awkward.

PLATE: So, wait. I'm a plate.

WITCH: Don't sell yourself short. You are not "a plate". You are a carefully crafted piece of fine china, a work of art, really.

PLATE: Right. So, hypothetically, when I was a person, if I, say, tripped and fell down the stairs, I would probably get a bruise. Skin my knee. Maybe sprain a wrist.

WITCH: RIght.

PLATE: Now, again hypothetically…

COAT RACK: (Whispers) I'm not sure you are using "hypothetically" correctly.

PLATE: …(Continues) let's say, as a plate…

COAT RACK; (Whispers) A carefully crafted piece of fine china, a work of art.

PLATE: …(Continues) as a carefully crafted piece of fine china, a work of art, I fall down those same stone stairs. What happens?

WITCH: Are they stone stairs?

PLATE: Does it matter?

WITCH: Not in the least. You would shatter into an incalculable amount of shards.

PLATE: I'd shatter into pieces?

WITCH: Oh no, pieces you could glue back together. Somewhere here there might be a hot glue gun, that's hit or miss sometimes. But it wouldn't matter: incalculable amount of fine shards. So fine and sharp I wouldn't even recommend trying to pick you up.

PLATE: What?

WITCH: Especially if it were in an out-of-the-way spot? I'd just leave you. Hope you slowly disintegrate or something.

PLATE: (Hand out, trying to come up with the next question.) So, when the curse is broken, and we all change back?

WITCH: I wouldn't recommend anyone you love seeing you when you turn back. Grisly.

PLATE: So, to sum up, I am cursed through no fault or power of my own, I cannot lift the curse through any power of my own, I could literally die with any false step, or even if I'm bumped into, and the only way I can hope to see my spouse again is if I help a spoiled, privileged, selfish prince find love and happiness?

WITCH: Spot on. Oh, and love with an independent, intelligent woman.

PLATE: Right. Can't forget the qualifiers.

WITCH: Well, to be honest, at the last witch's meeting, we all realized that most fairytales have the a sort of cookie cutter, shallow woman fall in love with an even more shallow rich prince. Not a lot of depth. And that's just not a good message to send out. We want our curses to have a better message.

FOOTSTOOL: That's really thoughtful of you all.

WITCH: Thank you. I'm actually the first one to try it. I'm really hoping for a good outcome.

FOOTSTOOL: Seems simple enough. How do we do that?

PLATE: Hold on. Because I don't have position or money, I have no control? No power?

WITCH: Spot on. But you do have the power to influence the prince to find love. Be a better person.

PLATE: So, he wouldn't listen to any of us when we were people, but he'll listen to a plate?

KNIFE: I'm a butcher's knife now, remember.

FOOTSTOOL: I bet Anita could make a pretty convincing argument then.

WITCH: It must be real, true love. It cannot be coerced.

PLATE: How are we to do this?

WITCH: It won't be easy.

FOOTSTOOL: WAIT! Curses have loopholes and stuff. It's like the genie's wish or the monkey's paw.

CUP: (Freaking out) Is there a genie inside me? Get it out, get it out, Someone rub me!

PLATE; There's no genie inside you. Someone poured tea in you.

CUP: Oh. (Seems to taste it.) Earl gray.

FOOTSTOOL: The love cannot be coerced.

WITCH: Correct.

FOOTSTOOL: But this is a curse on the prince. So the prince has to learn the lesson. Can the girl be coerced?

WITCH: What do you mean?

FOOTSTOOL: Can we figure out how to kidnap an independent, intelligent woman, hold her hostage, and then hope she slowly falls in love with the prince?

WITCH: Well, there's nothing against that, per se.

PLATE: I thought this was supposed to be a good message you wanted this story to send?

KNIFE: I *am* a butcher's knife!

FOOTSTOOL: But would it break any rules?

WITCH: Look, it doesn't technically break any rules. But I would advise against it.

FOOTSTOOL: Why?

WITCH: I'm not going to go into it here, there are countless YouTube videos and Reddit threads you can look at which will explain the problematic messages that plan would send.

PLATE: We don't get Internet here.

WITCH: What?

FOOTSTOOL: The Prince said it was a needless expense.

WITCH: What expense? The town has been on free Wi-fi for almost a year now.

FOOTSTOOL: WHAAAAAT?

WITCH: It was part of their rejuvenation plan to attract younger workers to the town. Remote work is here to stay, you know.

PLATE: So, we could be watching Netflix right now? Stranger Things could be on the table?

WITCH: The password is G@ST0N1. (That's a zero not the letter. Let that be a joke for just people who can connect it.)

FOOTSTOOL: (Pulls out the phone) Works! I can Insta!

CUP: I HAVE NO HANDS! How am I going to play Minecraft? (Or insert other phone-based game that is popular.)

PLATE: We need to find an independent, intelligent woman we can trick!

BROOM: I'm looking up Stockholm Syndrome!

FOOTSTOOL: I'm following a tinkerer's daughter who is intelligent, independent, and sort of seems alone with her head in the clouds.

WITCH: This is getting wildly out of control here. You shouldn't kidnap someone to make them fall in love with you.

PLATE: You set the rules, witch. If this is the system, we have to do what it takes.

COAT RACK: We do know the prince is persistent. Remember in high school? The crush? Every day standing with a flower and a box of money by her locker. What was her name?

FOOTSTOOL: Oh yeah…..

KNIFE: Her name was Anita!

FOOTSTOOL: That's it. What ever happened to her?

WITCH: There's a real fine line with persistence. You are sort of describing someone who stalks.

FOOTSTOOL: She followed me back!

PLATE: Now we are cooking.

FOOTSTOOL: I told her we had a great library and she should come check it out.

WITCH: She’s not going to be lulled with so phony an offer. No one’s that stupid.

PLATE: You said her intelligence was to be measured just by her love of books, not Internet scams.

WITCH: Well…

FOOTSTOOL: Shoot, I just got a text that my Amazon account was hacked and I need to click this link to confirm my account information or they’ll lock me out forever. I need to take care of this.

CUP: Is this when we make dinner? But it’s lunch. Am I hungry? Do we eat still?

BUCKET: (Walks up with sloshing.) Prince is up. In case you didn’t connect that sound, that’s sloshing. I will admit the Prince did at least apologize as we were (Searches for the right word) communing. So, that’s progress.

CUP: I don’t think that’s Earl Gray tea.

WITCH: Is the prince coming down?

PRINCE: What did I miss?

(KNOCK KNOCK KNOCK)

GIRL: I’m here for the library tour?

PLATE: Right this way.

WITCH: It’s a trap!

FOOTSTOOL: Solid reference.

COAT RACK: She ran away.

PRINCE: Was that a beautiful woman who had arrived looking to love me?

PLATE: (Same time as witch) Yes.

WITCH: (Same time as Plate) No.

PLATE: That was our best chance…

WITCH: Ok! That's it! Curse off!

BUCKET: Quick! Someone empty me out!

CUP: I like tea, so I don't mind it.

PRINCE: I sort of like being a super strong and agile beast person.

KNIFE: I'm still a knife!

PLATE: And I'm still a plate.

WITCH: Look, these things go sunset to sunrise. So, you'll have to tough it out until next sunrise. Plate, just go somewhere quiet and safe.

PRINCE: I'm going to run around the woods all beast like! Roar!

WITCH: Everyone just leave!

PRINCE: RABBIT!

NARRATOR: And so the witch sat alone in defeat. Hoping to change the messages of fairytales of lore, but failing miserably and almost creating an even more problematic set of messages, including, never try something new. The end. Roll credits.

PLATE: Hey.

WITCH: Plate, you stayed.

PLATE: This is sort of like the end credits stinger. I just wanted to say: Thank you.

WITCH: You ruined everything, you know.

PLATE: I mean, it's messed up I'm thanking you. You cursed us all for someone else's actions. Not our fault But you at least realized how you can't always control the message. People are going to people.

WITCH: And now the message is if you are annoying and vexing enough you'll get what you want.

PLATE: No position. No money. But anyone can be annoying and vexing.

WITCH: And the prince? He didn't even change. Not even a little.

PLATE: If anything he’s having fun out there as a beast.

WITCH: I hate it all sometimes.

PLATE: I get it.

WITCH: I just wanted to use my power to make the world a better place.

PLATE: You repaid negativity with negativity. It went wrong. Maybe we need to try just putting love and kindness into the world.

WITCH: And turn into Buckets?

PLATE: Maybe. Maybe not.

END PLAY